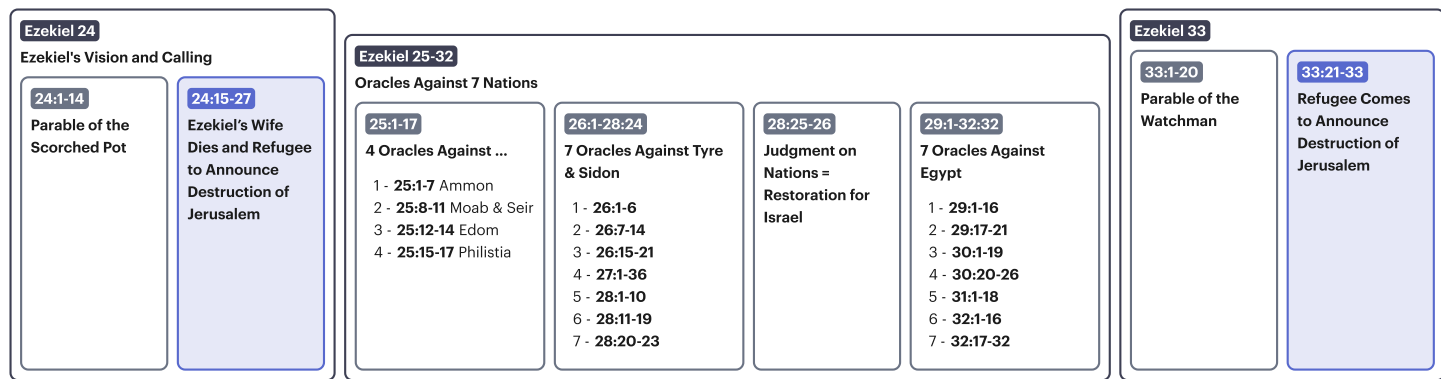


Session 15: The Destruction of the Temple

Key Takeaways

- Ezekiel 24 and 33 frame the oracles against the nations in 25-32. “Strike” in 24:16 is ambiguous, meaning either a sudden military defeat or a sudden plague.
- Like Aaron in Leviticus 10, the command for Ezekiel not to mourn is a call for him to maintain his role as a priest, wearing the turban and sandals representing new creation life instead of wearing the mourning clothes that reflect death.
- The loss of the beloved is a repeated element within the theme of the chosen one, building expectation that the messiah will suffer and die.

Literary Design of Ezekiel 24-33



Ezekiel 24-33. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Parable of the Scorched Pot (Ezek. 24:1-14)

Ezekiel 24:1-2 indicates that on this day in January 588 B.C.E., Babylon began its siege of Jerusalem that would last one and a half years (see 2 Kgs. 25:1-2).

Ezekiel uses the vivid parable of a filthy and defiled iron cauldron used for making stew, and how the temperature will be raised so high all the contents will be burned into a slag to clean the pot of its filth.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 24:15-27

Yahweh to Ezekiel

15

And the spoken-word of Yahweh came to me saying ,

16

Son of a human,

e behold, **I am going to take from you the desire of your eyes** with a strike;
and you will not mourn
and you will not weep
and your tears will not come.

17 Groan silently;
perform no mourning for **the dead**.
Bind on your turban upon you,
and put your shoes on your feet,
and do not cover your mustache,
and do not eat the bread of normal people."

Ezekiel to the People

18 **And I spoke to the people in the morning**,
and in the evening **my wife died**.
And in the morning **I did just as** I was commanded.

People to Ezekiel

19 **And the people said to me**,
"Won't you tell us,
what do these mean for us,
the things that you are doing?"

Ezekiel to the People

20 **And I said to them**,
" **The word of Yahweh came to me saying**,
21 'Speak to the house of Israel,
"Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
'**Look, I am going to defile my sacred space,**
the pride of your power (רָצוֹן),
the desire of your eyes,
and the delight of your soul;
and your sons and your daughters whom you left,
they will fall by the sword.
22 **You will do just as I have done**;
you will not cover your mustache,
and you will not eat the bread of normal people.
23 **Your turbans will be on your heads,**
and your shoes on your feet.
You will not mourn,
and you will not weep,
but you will rot in your iniquities,
and you will groan to one another.
24 **And so Ezekiel will be a sign to you**;

according to **all that he has done, so you will do** when it comes;
then you will know that I am Yahweh Elohim.”

Yahweh to Ezekiel

25 As for you, son of a human,
won't it be on the day **when I take from them,**
their stronghold (מַעֲזֵז),
the joy of their beauty,
the desire of their eyes,
and the burden of their soul, their sons and their daughters,
26 on that day, that the refugee will come to you with a report for your ears?
27 On that day your mouth will be opened for the refugee,
and you will speak and be mute no longer.
Thus you will be a sign to them,
and they will know that I am Yahweh.”

Ezekiel 24:15-27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Sign Act: Ezekiel's Wife and the Destruction of the Temple

This short narrative unit has been broken up into three parts. Parts 1 and 3 are an opening and closing speech from Yahweh to Ezekiel (24:16-17 and 24:25-27). These speeches surround a short narrative dialogue between Ezekiel and the people that proceeds in three steps.

Ezekiel 24:16-17

Yahweh to Ezekiel

- “And the spoken-word of Yahweh came to me, ‘Son of a human...’”
- **“I am going to take desire of your eyes...”**

Ezekiel 24:18-24

Ezekiel & The People

- **18** “And I spoke to the people...”
“and **my wife** died.”
- **19** “And the people said to me...”
- **20-24** “And I said to them...”
“I am going to defile the desire of your eyes...”

Ezekiel 24:25-27

Yahweh to Ezekiel

- “And you, son of a human...”
- “On the day that **I take from them...the desire of their eyes...**”

Ezekiel 24:16-27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

This literary design illuminates an ambiguity in Yahweh’s first words to Ezekiel in 24:16-17. It is not clear who or what exactly “the desire of your eyes” refers to when it is first mentioned.

When Ezekiel first hears this, it seems likely that he would understand it to refer to the Jerusalem temple. This is clearly what “the desire of your eyes” refers to later in 24:21 and 24:25.

The “Strike”

The word “strike” (Heb. *maggephah* מגפה, from *nagaph* נגף) is a metaphor, and can be used to refer to the plagues Yahweh sent upon Egypt (Exod. 9:14), to a sudden defeat in battle (1 Sam. 4:17; 2 Sam. 17:9, 18:7), or to a sudden outbreak of a disease (Num. 14:37; 16:48-50; 25:8-9, 18-19; 31:16; 1 Sam. 6:4; 2 Sam. 24:21, 25; Zech. 14:12, 15, 18; Ps. 106:29-30).

This ambiguity in the word *maggephah* allows the narrative to develop a dual meaning: “strike” as in defeat in battle or “plague” as in the outbreak of a disease.

The word “strike” also recalls the narrative pattern of the Exodus and wilderness wanderings of Israel, where this word refers to an act of severe divine judgment on human evil.

It seems likely that Ezekiel and the reader would understand the divine strike to refer to something in Jerusalem, that is, the ruin of the temple, the city, and the people.

No Public Mourning, but New Priestly Garments

Ezekiel is told that when this disaster happens, he is not to engage in public grieving that would defile his holy status as a priest. Yahweh’s instruction matches similar guidelines given to the priests in Leviticus 21:10-12, that even when their closest relative dies, they are not to change their clothes or deface their bodies (that is, take on ritual symbols of death).

The two lists of activities that Ezekiel and the people are to perform are arranged and coordinated in an important way.

and you will not mourn
and you will not weep,
and your tears will not come.

¹⁷ Groan silently;

perform no mourning for the dead .

Bind on your turban upon you,
and put your shoes on your feet,

and do not cover your mustache,
and do not eat the bread of normal people.”

22 y'all will not cover your mustaches,
and y'all will not eat the bread of normal people.

23 Y'all's turbans will be on your heads,
and y'all's shoes on your feet.

Y'all will not mourn,
and y'all will not weep,
but y'all will rot in your iniquities ,
and y'all will groan to one another.

Ezekiel 24:16-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Notice that the inner statements are identical, and that the similarity highlights the only difference: “you will rot in your iniquities,” which is set in parallelism with the phrase “perform mourning for the dead.”

Yahweh’s words to Ezekiel also mirror what Yahweh said to Aaron on the day that two of his sons violated the guidelines for behavior in the tabernacle, as they burst into the tent to offer incense that was not allowed (Lev. 10:1-7).

Not only is Ezekiel not to engage in public mourning, but he is to put on his priestly clothing as if he is preparing for liturgical duty (“put on your turban” recalls Exod. 39:27-28; see also Isa. 61:3 and Ezek. 44:18).

Based on the associations with the word “strike” and the prohibition to engage in public mourning, the first oracle given to Ezekiel would seem to be a preparation for a large-scale tragic event that will happen to Jerusalem. The shock of the following narrative, then, is that when Ezekiel awakes in the morning, it is not to the news of a destroyed Jerusalem temple. Rather, he finds out that his wife has died suddenly during the night.

The Loss of the Beloved

The death of Ezekiel’s wife fits into a narrative pattern in the Hebrew Bible where a person’s or a group’s failures finally catch up to them and become so grievous that Yahweh hands them over to their demise.

- Adam and Eve lose Abel, the son God favored, because of Cain’s jealous anger, though they receive Seth as a substitute (Gen. 4:1-10, 25-26).
- Abraham surrenders his “beloved” Isaac over to death, only to discover a last-moment substitute (Gen. 22).
- Rebekah surrenders her “beloved” Jacob over to exile, never to see him again (Gen. 28).
- Jacob surrenders his “beloved” Benjamin to descend down into Egypt and into prison, but Judah offers himself as a last-minute substitute (Gen. 43-45).

- Moses nearly loses his firstborn son in a nighttime plague, only to have his life saved through circumcision (Exod. 4:24-27).
- David loses his firstborn son with Bathsheba because of his moral failure of adultery and then murder (2 Sam. 11-12).
- Aaron loses his two firstborn sons because of their own failure in the tabernacle liturgy (Lev. 10:1-9).
This example is important because Ezekiel's story has been closely modeled after Aaron's loss as well.

Leviticus 10:1-7 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now Nadab and Abihu, the sons of Aaron,
they took their fire-censers, and after putting fire in them,
placed incense on it and offered strange fire before the LORD,
which he had not commanded them.

² And fire came out from the presence of the LORD and consumed them,
and they died before the LORD.

³ Then Moses said to Aaron,
"It is what the LORD spoke, saying,
'By those who come near me I will be treated as holy,
And before all the people I will be honored.'"

And Aaron kept silent.

⁴ Moses called also to Mishael and Elzaphan, the sons of Aaron's uncle Uzziel, and said to them,
"Come forward, carry your relatives away from the front of the sanctuary to the outside of the camp."

⁵ So they came forward and carried them still in their tunics to the outside of the camp, as Moses had said.

⁶ Then Moses said to Aaron and to his sons Eleazar and Ithamar,
"**Do not uncover your heads nor tear your clothes,**
so that you will not die,
and so that he will not become angry against all the congregation.
But your brothers, the whole house of Israel,
they will weep about the burning which Yahweh has burned.

⁷ You shall not even go out from the doorway of the tent of meeting, or you will die;
for Yahweh's anointing oil is upon you."
So they did according to the word of Moses.

Notice that the commands Yahweh gives to Aaron closely resemble those given to Ezekiel: both are silent instead of engaging in the customary mourning rituals and both are called not to weep in public.

Both priests are also called to put on (in Ezekiel's case) or to keep on (in Aaron's case) their symbolic priestly clothing, specifically the turban (a symbol of their royal-priestly status) and the sandals (a symbol of their readiness to walk into the temple).

Also significant is the reason that both priests are not to take upon themselves the clothing and practices of mourning for the dead. There is a great disaster looming, and Israel's priests are called to act as living symbols of the new humanity, a glowing and transformed human who can walk into and out of death and remain unharmed.

Ezekiel 24:26-27 serves an important role. A “refugee” from the destroyed Jerusalem is going to come, and the divine-dumbness of Ezekiel ([Ezek. 3:26](#)) will end. This is a compositional cue looking forward to chapter 33, the fall of Jerusalem in 586 B.C.E., and Ezekiel’s transition to become a prophet of hope. The gap between this date and the coming of the refugee was two years (1.5 years of the siege + 6 months of waiting for the news), and this gap is registered in the compositional structure of the book, as chapters 25-32 fill the interval.

Compositional Links with Ezekiel 12:1-16

In both this unit and [12:1-16](#), Ezekiel is commanded to engage in bizarre, symbolic behavior (12:6 carry luggage through the city at night, 24:18 abstain from mourning for dead wife).

In both, Ezekiel is questioned by an audience about the meaning of his behavior (12:9 and 24:19 are very close in Hebrew).

Ezekiel himself is described as a “sign for Israel” (Heb. *mophet*, 12:6, 11; 24:24, 27): 12:11 “just as I have done, so it will be done to them,” and 24:21 “you all shall do just as I have done.”

Reflection Question

How does the death of Ezekiel’s wife connect to the theme of the loss of the beloved in the rest of the Bible?
How does this pattern point to Jesus?